Outbidding CSN was only the first part. Nearly five weeks after the knockout bid from Tata's stable, on 7 March, Corus's shareholders voted overwhelmingly in favour of the Tata deal. And almost a month later, on 2 April 2007, Tata Steel officially acquired Corus, headquartered in the UK—ironically, the country that had inspired Jamsetji Tata to start the Indian steel company a century ago, and whose senior officials had mocked his efforts to produce steel in India during the colonial era.

Hugh Evans, a councillor, echoed what many Britishers may have felt. He lamented that the acquisition was 'terrifically ironical', because 'this plant was at one time actually supplying rail girders to India to develop an Indian rail company. And now of course an Indian company wants to buy it and develop it.' Others may have been less restrained in expressing their disappointment that a British steel company that had supported the manufacture of ships and weapons to further the country's colonial quest was now going into the very hands it had cuffed.

When nothing else could be raised as an objection, doubts were incredulously raised by Britishers about the 'safety' of the debt to Tata Steel. It mattered little to them that this was the same company to which even discerning US banks and investment houses had lent without wincing in the least, some half a century ago. Writing even before the deal was finalized, *The Independent* said: 'I don't doubt the industrial logic of combining with a low-cost producer from the emerging markets, but I do wonder about the safety of the debt being taken on to allow this to happen.'

Meanwhile, Ratan quickly drew up a strategy for Corus. The objective was clear. 'I think our plan would be to try and make the UK operations more profitable. The Netherlands operations are exceedingly competitive,' he told the *Financial Times*. He set himself to the task.

The Meltdown

Ratan was confident that the acquisition had more going in favour of the Tata Group than against it. He formed a seven-member committee to spearhead the integration with the Corus Group, with himself as the chairman. From Tata Steel, the members were Muthuraman, Chatterjee and Mukherjee. From Corus, the members were Varin, Executive Director (Finance) David Lloyd and Division Director (Strip Products) Rauke Henstra. The committee's mandate was to 'determine future strategic